

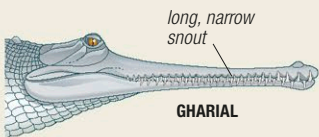
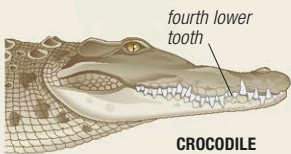
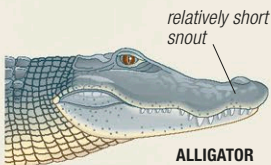
Crocodiles and alligators

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Crocodylia
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	25

These large reptiles are among the few survivors from the time of the dinosaurs, having changed little in the last 65 million years. Collectively known as crocodilians, they include crocodiles, alligators, and caimans, and one species of gharial. Crocodilians are formidable, semiaquatic predators. Most of them live in freshwater rivers, lakes, and lagoons, while a few species inhabit tidal reaches and may venture out to sea. Alligators and caimans (with the exception of one species) are found only in North, Central, and South America. Crocodiles occur mainly in Asia, Africa, and Australia, with some species in Central and South America.

Anatomy

All species of crocodilians have a wide, slightly flattened body, a long, vertically flattened, muscular tail, powerful jaws, and eyes and nostrils on top of the head so that they can see and breathe while partly submerged. A transparent third eyelid can be closed to protect their eyes when underwater. The large, bony scales have raised ridges, and are shed singly or in pieces, unlike those of other reptiles. Most are dull olive, gray, brown, or black, although juveniles may have lighter markings that disappear with age. The 3 groups of crocodilians differ in the shape of their snout and the arrangement of their teeth (see below).



SNOUT SHAPES

Alligators and caimans have shorter, broader snouts than crocodiles. The fourth lower tooth fits into a pit in the upper jaw and is not seen when the mouth is closed. Crocodiles, however, have a notch in their upper jaw, into which the fourth lower tooth fits so that the tooth remains visible when the mouth is shut. The gharial has a long, narrow snout with enlarged front teeth followed by smaller teeth of equal size.

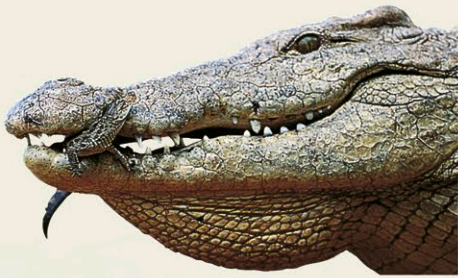
ADAPTATIONS FOR DIVING

Crocodilians have 2 adaptations to stop water entering their lungs when underwater. By closing a flap of skin at the back of the throat, they can open their mouth to catch prey without water passing down the windpipe. Similar flaps can also be closed over the external openings of the nostrils and ears.



Reproduction

Male crocodilians are territorial and mate with several females. Each female lays her eggs near water, either in a mound of vegetation and mud or in an underground chamber. The females guard the eggs and help the hatchlings out of the nest when they hear them calling. Females stay with their young for several months (a year or more in American alligators) to protect them from predators.



PARENTAL CARE

In most species, the female uses her mouth to carry her hatchlings to a shallow pool or backwater.

HUNTING LARGE PREY

Sometimes hunting cooperatively, large crocodilians, such as the Nile crocodile (shown here), are capable of overcoming animals as large as wildebeest or buffalo. After the kill, the carcass may be stored under an overhanging bank or log below the waterline to be eaten later.



Hunting and feeding

Crocodilians are carnivores that eat a mixture of live prey and carrion. They use various techniques when hunting but the most common is to lie in wait at the edges of rivers and lakes for mammals to come within range to drink or try to cross. Another method is to drift toward prey, such as waterfowl, hoping to catch it off guard. Fish-eating species, such as the gharial, take prey with a rapid sideways swipe of their narrow jaws, which offer little resistance to the water. Birds, small mammals, and fishes are swallowed whole, but as crocodilians cannot chew, they must dismember larger prey by spinning violently about their own axis while underwater, holding part of the carcass in their jaws.



HUNTING BY STEALTH

By drifting with only its eyes and nostrils above the water, a crocodilian can move to within striking range without being seen.

STORING FOOD

Having drowned this antelope, the crocodile may eat some of it before securing the remainder in an underwater "larder" to rot, making it easier to dismember.

